

Forced back to a regime they had escaped

Nicaraguan dissidents, once welcomed by the U.S., face deportation to their homeland.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND ISMAEL LÓPEZ

MEXICO CITY — Nicaraguan journalist Luis Galeano fled his country in 2018 after police raided the television station where he broadcast his popular talk show, arresting two of his colleagues.

Galeano applied for political asylum when he arrived in Florida on a tourism visa, saying he faced grave risks back home for his fierce criticism of Nicaragua's left-wing Sandinista government, which the U.S. labels a dictatorship. Soon after, Nicaragua declared Galeano a "traitor to the homeland" and confiscated his home and assets in the capital of Managua.

This week, U.S. immigration agents arrested Galeano in Orlando. Despite his ongoing asylum case, he now faces deportation to the country he fled and whose abuses he has spent years documenting.

Journalists, human rights advocates and political dissidents who were persecuted in Nicaragua and sought safety in the United States are increasingly being detained as the Trump administration widens its deportation dragnet and narrows access to asylum and other forms of protection.

Recent targets include activists who fled Nicaragua after a bloody crackdown on pro-democracy protests in 2018 and opposition leaders critical of the regime of Daniel Ortega and Rosario Murillo, a married couple who lead Nicaragua as co-presidents.

Some of the exiles arrested by U.S. agents in recent months had been welcomed with open arms by the U.S. government just [See Nicaragua, A4]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

AN SUV collided with a Metro bus Tuesday afternoon, killing two. The helicopter crashed nearby two hours later, killing two on board and a third on the ground.

Recording holds clues in news helicopter crash

Accident kills three, including two NBC4 journalists covering Chatsworth bus crash.

By RICHARD WINTON, SALVADOR HERNANDEZ, HANNAH FRY, IRIS KWOK AND TERRY CASTLEMAN

It was a night of devastation in Chatsworth that began with a deadly Metro bus collision and ended with the fiery crash of an NBC4 helicopter covering the news that left two journalists and,

on the ground, a bystander dead.

Tuesday's scene was a mixture of confusion and chaos, with first responders fanned out across two catastrophes and TV news teams desperately trying to find out whether their journalists were safe. The crashes claimed the lives of five people and left others with various degrees of injury.

Investigators with the National Transportation Safety Board and the Federal Aviation Administration were trying Wednesday to determine exactly what caused the news helicopter,

a Eurocopter AS350 B2, to go down.

NTSB Investigator Fabian Salazar said officials are searching through the wreckage, combing through maintenance logbooks, security footage, weather reports and witness interviews, and reviewing the pilot's training to figure out what went wrong.

But the most critical information so far has been audio captured from the helicopter during a live broadcast of reporter Eliana Moreno and pilot George Marciniw's final moments [See Chatsworth, A6]

DUTY, DANGER: Columnist chronicles perils of traffic reporting. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

LAUSD weighs fate of schools as enrollment dives

District officials face tough choices on 'rebuilding while also downsizing' campuses.

By HOWARD BLUME

Enrollment in Los Angeles schools has taken another steep dive — about 4% this year — as officials press ahead with a multibillion-dollar modernization and rebuilding plan, raising questions about investing in campuses that may soon be shuttered.

The school closure issue was supposed to move forward Tuesday, as the Board of Education was slated to vote on hiring a consultant to advise in that arena. But the contract was pulled from consideration at the last moment after mounting alarm among parent activists and employee groups. Instead, Supt. Andrés Chait hit the reset button with a districtwide message.

"When schools become very small, it can be harder to provide the full range of opportunities our students deserve," Chait wrote. "That is why, over the coming weeks, we will begin a community conversation about how we can strengthen our schools and make sure every

student has access to the opportunities and support they need to succeed."

"Our goal is not simply to have fewer schools," he added. "Our goal is to have stronger schools."

The decisions weigh heavily into imminent issues confronting the Board of Education, which must carry out a budget-cutting plan to prevent a deficit that, in a worst-case scenario, could increase to \$3.5 billion by June 30, 2029. Layoffs, unpaid staff furloughs and school closures probably are ahead as the leaders downsize operations.

At the same time, the school district has proceeded full force into its ongoing school reconstruction and modernization program, which voters buttressed in November 2024 with \$9 billion in bonds.

On Tuesday, the board approved major reconstruction projects at four elementary schools for a combined \$322.6 million — Menlo Avenue, 93rd Street, 96th Street and 122nd Street, all in South Los Angeles. These projects were taken on to address earthquake risks and then expanded in scope.

In June, the board approved three other seismic-risk reconstructions totaling \$496.9 million: Nor-

[See Schools, A6]



The Cassirer Family Trust

A DISPUTED Camille Pissarro painting hangs in the Cassirer family's home in Germany in the 1920s.

Reclaiming art looted by Nazis

Families sue museums, including the Norton Simon, in an effort to get works back.

By KEVIN RECTOR

For the first time since California and Congress passed a pair of laws bolstering U.S.-based claims to Nazi-looted artwork around the world, two lawsuits have been filed in California demanding prominent museums relinquish pieces seized during World War II.

In one case, filed in federal court in Los Angeles on Monday, the daughters of Auschwitz survivor Dina Gottliebova Babbitt sued the Auschwitz-Birkenau Memorial and Museum in Poland for the return of watercolors Babbitt was forced to paint of fellow prisoners for the Nazi physician and war criminal Josef Mengele.

In the other, filed in Los Angeles Superior Court on Monday, the Jewish Federa-

tion of Greater Los Angeles and Daniel Gryczman, the federation's board chair, sued the Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena for the return of the diptych "Adam and Eve," a pair of 16th century masterpieces by Lucas Cranach the Elder.

The lawsuits revive legal battles waged unsuccessfully for the watercolors and the diptych for years, on the premise that their claims are newly viable under the new laws — one passed by California lawmakers in 2024 and the other signed into law by President Trump earlier this year.

Both laws were inspired in part by another legal battle over looted art between a California family and a prominent museum, which is still ongoing.

Lilly Cassirer Neubauer escaped Germany at the dawn of World War II by relinquishing to a Nazi art broker the exquisite Impressionist masterpiece "Rue Saint-Honoré in the Afternoon. Effect of Rain," by [See Art, A7]

EU offers to make Canada 'associate'

The proposal touting 'common strength' comes as relationships with U.S. are fraying.

By ROB GILLIES

STRASBOURG, France — European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen on Wednesday pro-

posed making Canada the European Union's first associate member, a striking overture as President Trump's threats drive Ottawa closer to Europe.

Trump's tariffs and repeated talk of making Canada the 51st state have soured the relationship between the North American neighbors. Canada is seeking to reduce its dependence on the United States, the destina-

tion for roughly 70% of its exports, and Prime Minister Mark Carney has called for a "unique alliance" with the EU.

In her annual State of the European Union address, Von der Leyen said Canada and the EU would build on their existing free trade agreement, known as CETA, with a broader "Alliance for the Future" aimed at creating "a common prosperity

and economic security space."

She cast that closer relationship as rooted not just in trade but in shared democratic values.

"Above all, dear Mark, Europe and Canada believe in democracy," Von der Leyen said to Carney, who received a standing ovation at the European Parliament in Strasbourg. He is due to [See Canada, A4]

La Opinión reflects on century in L.A.

About a dozen Spanish-language newspapers were operating in Los Angeles when Ignacio E. Lozano Sr. launched La Opinión.

It was Mexican Independence Day in 1926, a few years before the Great Depression and the forced removal of Mexicans and Mexican Americans that followed.

Through it all, La Opinión stood the test of time. It chronicled the lives of the city's growing Mexican community for generations, reaching huge levels of influence in the 1980s and 1990s as immigration from Mexico and Central America reshaped the region in profound demographic and political ways.

This week, the paper reached a milestone, marking a century covering L.A.'s increasingly diverse Latino

For generations, the influential Spanish-language paper was a lifeline

By Ruben Vives



CRAIG MATHEW Associated Press

ROSALINA Villanueva browses papers downtown in 1986. The decade was an era of growth for La Opinión.

community. Though it has faced struggles similar to other newspapers, it remains a presence, including last year when Los Angeles was roiled by the Trump administration's immigration crackdown.

The paper's centennial is "an amazing feat," said David LiCalzi, chief operating officer of MyCode, the company that has owned La Opinión since 2022. It's a reminder of the company's responsibility in stewarding one of the country's longest-running Spanish-language newspapers, he said.

In today's world of news apps and social media, it's easy to forgo the influence newspapers like La Opinión had. For many immigrants who did not speak English, a Spanish-language news- [See La Opinión, A11]

Homeless funding fraud alleged

Three are charged at nonprofits that received taxpayer money via an L.A. agency. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Implications of Fed's rate hike

The quarter-point bump is bad news for borrowers, good news for savers. **BUSINESS, A9**

Free home game tickets for Bruins

In effort to pack venues, UCLA offers students no-cost entry to football, basketball. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 80/64. **B6**

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